



ECA



ESCWA

Regional Dialogue on AI Governance in Africa: Consultation Report

Jointly Organized by ECA and ESCWA

Addis Ababa, Ethiopia

April 27, 2026

Contents

Introduction	3
Background and Global Context	3
Regional Context: Africa’s AI Landscape	3
The Regional Dialogue on AI Governance.....	4
Opening Session.....	5
Regional Reflections and Consultations	7
Thematic Cluster A: AI opportunities and implications: Societal, Cultural, Ethical, Linguistic, Technical, and Economic Dimensions	7
Thematic Cluster B: Bridging AI divides: capacity-building, access, and digital foundations.	8
Thematic Cluster C: Safe, secure and trustworthy AI: responsible and interoperable approaches.....	11
Thematic Cluster D: Respecting, protecting and promoting human rights: transparency, accountability and human oversight.....	13
Thematic Cluster E: Africa’s Role in Global AI Governance.....	13
Addis Ababa Declaration on Regional Dialogue on AI Governance.....	14
I. AI Development and Digital Sovereignty	14
II. Trustworthy and Inclusive AI Governance.....	14
III. Global Engagement and Implementation	15
Recommendations.....	15
Recommendations for the UN and International Partners.....	15
Recommendations for Member States	16
Conclusion.....	17

Introduction

Background and Global Context

Artificial intelligence (AI) governance is increasingly anchored within evolving global frameworks led by the United Nations, including the establishment of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance under General Assembly Resolution 79/325 and the adoption of the Global Digital Compact within the Pact for the Future in September 2024. These processes reflect a growing international consensus that AI governance is both a test of multilateral cooperation and a necessary condition for ensuring that AI contributes meaningfully to sustainable development. Through these mechanisms, Member States and stakeholders are engaging in inclusive, structured dialogue to address critical issues such as capacity gaps, data governance, and institutional readiness, while aligning AI development with the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals.

Within this context, AI is increasingly positioned as both a cross-cutting enabler of socio-economic transformation and a domain of emerging risks requiring urgent and coordinated governance responses. The growing deployment of frontier technologies has intensified concerns around ethical AI, data governance, transparency, and accountability, alongside broader socio-economic and cultural implications. As emphasized in global discussions, including reflections by António Guterres, the challenge lies in navigating this dual reality, harnessing the transformative potential of AI while mitigating its risks through responsible and inclusive governance. This sense of urgency underpins ongoing global and regional consultations, which aim to define priorities, shape governance approaches, and ensure that AI systems are safe, secure, and aligned with human rights and development objectives.

Regional Context: Africa's AI Landscape

Artificial intelligence is rapidly emerging as a transformative driver across Africa, with applications spanning healthcare, agriculture, finance, education, and public administration. Recognizing this potential, the African Union adopted the Continental AI Strategy in 2024, advancing an Africa-centric, inclusive, and development-oriented vision for harnessing AI to accelerate socioeconomic transformation. Across the continent, AI ecosystems are expanding, with a significant rise in startups, talent, and investment, reflecting growing recognition of AI as a strategic priority. However, despite this momentum, Africa's overall adoption levels remain comparatively low, limiting its projected share in global AI-driven economic gains.

The current landscape is characterized by a dynamic yet uneven ecosystem. While the number of AI companies and professionals has grown substantially, development remains fragmented, with disparities in infrastructure, skills, and institutional readiness across countries. Policy and regulatory gaps persist, particularly in areas such as data governance, ethical standards, and cross-border coordination. At the same time, there is a growing trend toward the development of national AI strategies in several countries, signaling increasing political commitment to

positioning AI within national development agendas, though implementation capacities vary widely.

Historically, AI governance in Africa has evolved from earlier efforts focused on ICT policy and digital transformation toward more targeted and complex governance frameworks addressing AI-specific challenges. This evolution reflects a broader shift in policy priorities, from enabling connectivity and digital access to managing data, algorithms, and emerging technologies. Increasingly, African countries are placing emphasis on issues of data sovereignty, local innovation ecosystems, and the ethical implications of AI deployment, particularly in relation to inclusion, language diversity, and societal impact.

This shift is further reinforced by the recognition that AI development in Africa is largely problem-driven, with innovation concentrated in sectors aligned with pressing development needs, such as healthcare, agriculture, and financial services. At the same time, the rapid advancement of technologies such as generative AI is intensifying the urgency for coherent governance approaches that can balance innovation with risk mitigation. As a result, strengthening policy frameworks, investing in skills and infrastructure, and fostering regional coordination have become central priorities for ensuring that AI contributes effectively to inclusive and sustainable development across the continent.

The Regional Dialogue on AI Governance

The Regional Dialogue on AI Governance was convened as part of the Eighth African Regional Science, Technology and Innovation Forum, held from 26–27 April 2026 in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia. Organized by the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa (ECA) in collaboration with the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia (ESCWA) as observer, the dialogue took place under the broader theme of advancing transformative and coordinated actions for the 2030 Agenda and Agenda 2063. The session, held on 27 April 2026, served as a high-level multi-stakeholder platform, bringing together policymakers, international organizations, academia, private sector representatives, civil society, and youth to deliberate on regional priorities and perspectives on AI governance.

The dialogue was designed to translate the global mandate on AI governance into actionable, regionally grounded priorities, reflecting the socioeconomic and digital realities of Africa and the Arab region. It facilitated inclusive and evidence-based discussions on key issues such as human rights, data governance, capacity gaps, and the ethical and socio-economic implications of AI. By fostering open and transparent exchanges, the consultation enabled participants to share best practices, identify common challenges, and explore collaborative approaches to building safe, secure, and trustworthy AI systems, while promoting policy harmonization and interoperability across regions.

Importantly, the dialogue contributed to building regional consensus on priority areas for AI governance and aligning African perspectives with ongoing global processes. It provided a platform to articulate a more coordinated African voice in shaping international AI governance

frameworks, ensuring that regional priorities, development aspirations, and contextual realities are adequately reflected. The outcomes of the consultation were intended to inform the inaugural global dialogue on AI governance scheduled for July 2026 in Geneva, including through the provision of concrete policy messages, identified collaboration areas, and a shared understanding of both opportunities and risks associated with AI in the regions.

The session was structured into four main segments: opening statements; regional reflections moderated by Mactar Seck, Chief of Emerging and Frontier Technologies, Innovation and Digital Transformation at the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa, and Federica Falomi, Head of Programme at the United Nations Technology Bank; an interactive roundtable consultation; and the presentation of a draft declaration for Africa on AI governance, reflecting the collective inputs and priorities articulated throughout the dialogue, followed by a closing ceremony.

Opening Session

The opening session of the Regional Dialogue on AI Governance set a strategic and forward-looking tone, positioning Africa at a critical juncture in shaping global artificial intelligence governance. The session brought together high-level representatives from governments and the United Nations system, and framed discussions around five priority pillars aligned with the Global Digital Compact: connectivity, inclusion, cybersecurity, data governance, and AI governance. It was highlighted that Africa represents approximately 13% of the global population but attracts only about 1% of global AI investment, while AI could contribute up to 8% of GDP if effectively leveraged. In setting the scene, Mr. Seck emphasized that *“AI governance must be approached as a cross-cutting priority balancing opportunity, security, skills development, and ethical considerations to unlock Africa’s full potential.”*

High-level interventions further underscored that this regional consultation forms an integral part of a broader, structured global process toward the Global Dialogue on AI Governance.

Ms. Thilmeeza Hussain, Director of the United Nations Regional Commissions New York Office, emphasized the bridging role of regional commissions in global policymaking, noting that *“what is articulated in Addis Ababa will travel to Geneva, and the world will be watching whether global AI governance genuinely reflects diverse regional perspectives.”* Echoing this,

H.E. Ambassador, Egriselda Lopez, Permanent Representative of El Salvador to the United Nations, Co-Chair of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance, stressed that the Global Dialogue must be practical and impactful, stating that *“it should not be a symbolic exercise, but an action-oriented platform that connects initiatives and delivers real value for Member States.”* She stressed that the credibility of the global process will depend on whether all regions, especially Africa and the Arab states, are meaningfully represented. The co-chair positioned the dialogue organized in Addis Ababa as a substantive input into a multi-stage preparatory process that has already included consultations across major global hubs such as New York, Paris, and Geneva, with engagement from key international organizations and

multi-stakeholder actors. Within this continuum, the Africa dialogue was framed as a critical mechanism to ensure that regional realities, particularly those relating to infrastructure gaps, data access, skills shortages, financing constraints, and institutional readiness are embedded into the design and outcomes of the global process.

H.E. Ambassador Rein Tammsaar, Permanent Representative of Estonia to the United Nations, Co-Chair of the Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance, complementing this perspective, highlighted the need for coherence in an increasingly complex governance landscape, emphasizing that *“the priority is not to duplicate efforts, but to connect and strengthen existing mechanisms in a coherent and interoperable way”*. He emphasized that the Global Dialogue on AI Governance, mandated by a United Nations General Assembly resolution, will unfold through a structured sequence of engagements, including a first session in 2026 and a follow-up session in 2027. The process is being deliberately designed to move beyond high-level principles toward practical and operational outcomes. In this regard, the dialogue will be organized around four thematic clusters:

- 1) **AI opportunities and implications: social, economic, ethical, cultural, linguistic and technical dimensions** - 4(c) the social, economic, ethical, cultural, linguistic and technical implications of AI.
- 2) **Bridging AI divides: capacity-building, access and digital foundations** - 4(b) capacity gaps, with a view to leveraging existing United Nations and multi-stakeholder mechanisms to support AI capacity-building to bridge AI divides, facilitate access to AI applications and build capacity in high-performance computing and related skills in developing countries; 4(g) the development of open-source software, open data and open artificial intelligence models.
- 3) **Safe, secure and trustworthy AI: interoperability and compatibility of approaches** - 4(a) the development of safe, secure and trustworthy AI systems; 4(d) the interoperability and compatibility of artificial intelligence governance approaches.
- 4) **Respecting, protecting and promoting human rights: transparency, accountability and human oversight** - 4(e) respect for and protection and promotion of human rights in the field of AI; 4(f) the transparency, accountability and robust human oversight of artificial intelligence systems in a manner that complies with international law.

These reflect both opportunities and challenges, including AI’s societal and economic implications, as well as the urgent need to bridge divides in access to infrastructure, data, skills, and compute capacity.

The co-chairs collectively highlighted that the objective is to build coherence across an increasingly fragmented AI governance landscape by linking ongoing efforts, identifying lessons learned, and strengthening interoperability across frameworks. This includes drawing on existing regional strategies and global processes, while ensuring that governance approaches remain grounded in real-world development contexts and responsive to national and regional priorities.

In outlining the forward trajectory, it was further noted that the global dialogue will include high-level plenary sessions, thematic discussions, and dedicated multi-stakeholder engagement segments designed to foster interaction between scientific evidence, policy perspectives, and practical experiences. The outcomes of these discussions will be consolidated into a co-chairs’

summary, which will guide follow-up actions and inform subsequent global engagements, including the second dialogue session.

From a national and development perspective, ministers emphasized AI as both an opportunity and a responsibility. **H.E. Deputy Minister, Sarjoh Aziz Kamara from Sierra Leone Technical and Higher Education**, underscored the transformative potential of AI, stating that *“AI is not simply a technological trend, but a strategic tool for national transformation capable of advancing education, innovation, and employment if deployed responsibly.”* He further emphasized the importance of investing in skills, infrastructure, and data governance systems, while ensuring that young people become creators of African solutions rather than passive consumers.

Collectively, the opening session highlighted a dual imperative of harnessing AI as a driver of inclusive growth while addressing risks related to inequality, ethics, and governance gaps. Speakers consistently called for strengthened regional coordination, investment in foundational digital infrastructure, and the development of inclusive, rights-based governance frameworks. The session therefore established a clear direction for the dialogue: to move beyond principles toward actionable priorities, and to ensure that Member States speak with a coordinated and influential voice in the evolving global AI governance architecture.

Regional Reflections and Consultations

Thematic Cluster A: AI opportunities and implications: Societal, Cultural, Ethical, Linguistic, Technical, and Economic Dimensions

The regional reflections under this cluster converged on the understanding that artificial intelligence is no longer a future-oriented concept but a present and rapidly evolving driver of structural transformation across Africa and Arab States. Participants consistently situated the discussion within the framework of the African Continental AI Strategy (2024), which was described as a critical milestone for articulating a coordinated and African-centred approach to AI governance. The contributions underscored that Africa’s AI trajectory must remain firmly anchored in structural realities such as infrastructure deficits, particularly electricity access and digital connectivity gaps, rather than replicating externally designed governance or innovation models.

From an economic and investment standpoint, the representative of Tunisia highlighted that Africa’s AI challenge is not primarily one of ideas or innovation potential, but rather of financial architecture and investment flows. Despite the global AI economy being projected to reach multi-trillion-dollar value creation by 2030, Africa remains significantly under-positioned in terms of venture capital allocation and innovation financing. This imbalance was interpreted as a systemic governance issue, with the strong assertion that capital allocation itself constitutes a form of governance, and without targeted financial instruments, AI governance frameworks risk remaining largely declarative rather than operational. This perspective linked economic structuring directly to governance effectiveness, reinforcing the need for integrated policy and investment ecosystems.

Cultural, linguistic, and ethical dimensions emerged as a central concern, with Egypt and Nigeria drawing attention to Africa's linguistic diversity, which encompasses over 2,000 languages. Despite this richness, less than 0.02 per cent of global digital content is currently available in African languages, raising serious concerns about exclusion in AI systems that are predominantly trained on non-African datasets. This structural imbalance was identified as a key risk factor that could undermine usability, accessibility, and trust in AI technologies across African societies. The importance of developing African-owned datasets and locally grounded AI models was further emphasized, arguing that without such foundations, AI systems risk reinforcing dependency and external epistemic dominance. The collective warning emerging from these interventions was clear; AI systems that do not reflect African realities risk becoming socially rejected, functionally irrelevant, or exclusionary in practice.

Gender and inclusion considerations were strongly articulated, which reframed the discourse by challenging the classification of women as a vulnerable group, instead positioning them as equal decision-makers whose exclusion is primarily structural rather than incidental. The intervention emphasized that inclusion must move beyond symbolic participation to become institutionalized, verifiable, and accountable. This includes the establishment of safe consultation mechanisms for children, ethically grounded participation frameworks, and independent verification systems to ensure that stakeholder inputs are effectively reflected in policy outcomes. The emphasis was placed on shifting from procedural inclusion to measurable influence in governance processes, thereby strengthening legitimacy and accountability in AI policymaking.

Across the cluster, innovation was repeatedly framed as a development-oriented imperative, with particular emphasis on sectors such as agriculture, education, healthcare, climate resilience, and drug discovery, which collectively hold significant potential for economic and social transformation (an estimated \$1.2 to \$1.5 trillion to the African economy by 2030, approx. 6% of GDP). Within this framing, AI was viewed as an enabling tool for inclusive development, structural transformation, and long-term economic diversification. [OBJ]

Thematic Cluster B: Bridging AI divides: capacity-building, access, and digital foundations

The regional consultations under this cluster converged on a strong and consistent diagnosis that Africa's AI divide is fundamentally rooted not in a lack of ambition or innovation potential, but in deep-seated gaps in capacity, infrastructure, and data readiness. This framing was particularly reinforced by ESCWA representative, which emphasized that AI capacity-building must be understood not as a short-term project-based intervention, but as a continuous governance system spanning policymakers, regulators, civil servants, and technical communities. In this regard, capacity development was positioned as an institutional architecture rather than an ad hoc technical assistance activity, with clear alignment to established global digital governance processes such as the World Summit on the Information Society (WSIS), the Internet Governance Forum (IGF), and the Global Digital Compact

(GDC). Within this framing, it was emphasized that governance coherence depends on linking AI policy directly with data governance, open science, and open innovation ecosystems, particularly to ensure that developing countries are not left at the margins of emerging AI value chains.

A further structural dimension was introduced through a scientific and institutional perspective emphasizing that capacity-building must be understood as a prerequisite for AI sovereignty. In this regard, it was stressed that Africa must move decisively from AI consumption to AI production by deliberately building foundational capabilities across data infrastructure, human capital, research systems, and technical governance. A key insight highlighted that without robust, open, and representative datasets across critical sectors such as education, agriculture, climate, and public administration, AI systems will continue to misrepresent African realities and undermine trust in digital systems.

Within the education and skills dimension, Ethiopia provided a concrete institutional perspective on how bridging the AI divide requires structural transformation of learning systems rather than incremental reform. The Ethiopia experience highlighted a deliberate shift away from theory-heavy and examination-oriented education models toward practical, project-based learning systems that emphasize innovation, prototyping, and applied problem-solving. A notable operational innovation introduced in this context is the adoption of shared server-based classroom systems, designed to enable multiple learners to access computing resources simultaneously in environments where individual device access is constrained. This model reflects a pragmatic response to infrastructure limitations, particularly in energy-constrained and resource-limited settings, and demonstrates how inclusive digital learning can be scaled through adaptive technological design rather than high-cost infrastructure replication.

Additionally, a strong emphasis was placed on the development of structured teacher-mentor pipelines for STEAM education, and the localization of AI systems in African languages to ensure meaningful inclusion in knowledge production. This was reinforced by a broader scientific perspective stressing that Africa must simultaneously build data infrastructure, human capital from early education levels, and local research and model development capacity. Without these foundations, there is a risk that Africa remains structurally dependent on externally developed AI systems, with limited capacity to detect algorithmic bias, govern data use, or shape innovation trajectories.

In this context, an academic representative further reinforced that human capital development must be comprehensive and span the entire education pipeline, from primary education through to advanced research and innovation systems. It was emphasized that scientific literacy and technical capability must be built early and systematically to ensure a sustainable pipeline of AI talent capable of contributing to deep-tech innovation. The intervention underscored the importance of developing local AI model-building capacity and integrating indigenous African languages into AI systems, noting that without this, AI systems risk remaining externally imposed and socially misaligned. A further critical dimension highlighted was the need for technical and regulatory assurance capacity, including the ability to detect algorithmic bias,

assess system risks, and ensure data privacy and system integrity, positioning African institutions not only as users of AI but also as governors and auditors of AI systems.

In the case of Sierra Leone, the broader education transformation agenda reinforced the centrality of capacity-building as a national development priority. The integration of AI into universities and technical institutions, combined with investments in ICT infrastructure and digital learning platforms, reflects a strategic effort to modernize higher education systems. However, this transformation is explicitly guided by the principle that AI must enhance creativity, innovation, and problem-solving rather than replace human judgment or undermine academic integrity. This reinforces the broader regional consensus that bridging AI divides must be aligned with safeguarding institutional quality and educational outcomes.

A further critical dimension of the discussion centered on data governance and AI-ready infrastructure. The GIZ's regional programme emphasized that one of the most significant structural constraints in Africa is not the absence of data, but the lack of structured, interoperable, and machine-readable datasets. In response, the Data Governance in Africa initiative, with an investment envelope of approximately €60 million, is supporting the development of AI-ready data indexing systems, open data catalogues, and harmonized cross-border data governance frameworks. These interventions are aimed at enabling data to move beyond static availability toward functional usability in AI systems. The initiative also underscores the importance of strengthening data centres and internet exchange points as foundational digital infrastructure, without which meaningful AI deployment at scale cannot be achieved.

From an innovation and investment ecosystem perspective, Tunisia highlighted what was described as a structural "AI instruments deficit," referring to the absence of practical enablers that translate policy intent into operational AI systems. These include weak regulatory sandboxes, fragmented procurement systems, and limited cross-border mobility of AI talent. The Tunisian intervention proposed a set of corrective mechanisms, including the establishment of an Africa–Middle East AI regulatory sandbox to enable controlled experimentation across jurisdictions, the creation of shared compute infrastructure, and the development of a dedicated AI innovation fund linking African and Middle Eastern ecosystems. These proposals reflect a broader recognition that financing and institutional experimentation environments are as critical as technical capacity in enabling scalable AI ecosystems.

Across all interventions, a shared emphasis emerged on the importance of open systems as foundational enablers of equitable AI development. Open-source software, open data ecosystems, and open artificial intelligence models were consistently identified as essential mechanisms for reducing dependency, expanding access, and fostering local innovation. These open systems were framed not only as technical solutions but also as governance enablers that can democratize participation in AI development, particularly for countries with limited financial and computational resources.

Overall, the consultations underscored that bridging AI divides requires a systemic approach that integrates education reform, data infrastructure development, regulatory innovation, and open-source ecosystems within a coherent capacity-building framework. The emphasis consistently moved away from fragmented interventions toward integrated, multi-layered governance systems capable of addressing structural inequalities in access, capability, and participation.

Thematic Cluster C: Safe, secure and trustworthy AI: responsible and interoperable approaches

The consultations converged on a strong normative and practical consensus that effective AI governance must be anchored in simplicity, interoperability, and risk-awareness, rather than regulatory over-complexity. Across the discussion, participants from UN system entities, regional commissions, and multi-stakeholder expert communities emphasized that the accelerating pace of AI development, including the emergence of agent-based systems and increasingly autonomous human-machine interaction models, requires governance frameworks that are both future-proof and grounded in stable principles. Reflections framed this as the need to establish a minimum set of shared global standards for AI governance, drawing an explicit analogy to universal human rights principles as long-term, widely accepted normative baselines. This approach was consistently positioned as essential to avoid fragmentation while enabling countries at different levels of readiness to participate meaningfully in global AI systems.

A central political and technical consensus emerged around the principle that interoperability, rather than full harmonization, should define the global AI governance architecture. In this framing, countries retain full sovereign authority over their national AI strategies, but operate within a shared baseline of global principles that ensure compatibility across systems, standards, and regulatory approaches. The Western Asia perspective reinforced this by drawing on lessons from earlier global digital governance processes such as WSIS and the Internet Governance Forum, which demonstrated the effectiveness of a dual-track model combining intergovernmental coordination with multi-stakeholder participation. This was further reinforced by the argument that AI governance should not be designed from scratch, as many regions, including Africa and the Arab States, already possess emerging AI strategies and frameworks. The challenge, therefore, is not conceptual design but practical implementation, moving from policy articulation to operational governance that delivers real-world outcomes.

Within this context, a strong forward-looking risk governance dimension was introduced, the need for adaptive governance systems that are not static but continuously responsive to technological change. The emphasis was placed on building governance structures that are technically grounded, flexible, and capable of evolving alongside AI innovation, while maintaining stable ethical and legal foundations. The consultation underscored that without such adaptability, governance frameworks risk becoming obsolete in relation to the speed of technological advancement.

A complementary institutional perspective emphasized that safe and trustworthy AI cannot be achieved without strengthening foundational governance indicators. Insights from international policy and strategy expertise highlighted three critical dimensions of institutional readiness: industry self-regulation mechanisms, rule of law and enforcement capacity, and robust ethical governance frameworks. These were presented as mutually reinforcing pillars necessary to prevent systemic risks such as algorithmic bias, misuse of AI systems, and weak accountability structures. In this context, regulatory and hybrid sandboxes were widely recognized as essential instruments for enabling responsible experimentation, allowing governments and private actors to test AI applications in controlled environments while managing risks and safeguarding public interest.

The consultations also highlighted that trustworthy AI governance is inseparable from issues of access, capacity, and global equity. A key concern raised was that fragmented regulatory ecosystems and uneven levels of institutional readiness risk reinforcing digital dependency and widening global inequalities in AI development and deployment. This was particularly emphasized in relation to developing regions, where weak enforcement systems, limited technical capacity, and unequal access to AI infrastructure can undermine both trust and effectiveness of governance frameworks. As a result, there was strong agreement that international cooperation must focus not only on rule-setting but also on enabling equitable access to AI capabilities, strengthening institutional capacity, and supporting countries with lower levels of technological readiness.

From a systems perspective, the consultations reinforced that responsible AI governance must integrate multiple layers of governance coherence, including alignment between AI governance and data governance, as well as the promotion of open science, open-source systems, and open innovation ecosystems. These were identified as critical enablers of transparency, accountability, and inclusive innovation, particularly in support of sustainable development objectives. Sectoral focus areas such as health, education, and public service delivery were repeatedly highlighted as priority domains where trustworthy AI systems can deliver the most immediate development impact, provided governance frameworks are both robust and context sensitive.

Overall, the discussion on safe, secure, and trustworthy AI reflected a clear shift away from purely normative debates toward implementation-oriented governance design. There was broad convergence that AI governance must balance sovereignty with interoperability, innovation with risk management, and global coordination with regional contextualization. The emerging consensus positions minimum global standards, adaptive regulatory systems, and interoperable governance architectures as the foundation for ensuring that AI development remains safe, secure, and aligned with human-centric values.

Thematic Cluster D: Respecting, protecting and promoting human rights: transparency, accountability and human oversight

Discussions reiterated that indigenous knowledge and cultural institutions need to be conserved and incorporated into AI innovation and not just rely on digital or online sources. It was emphasized that direct interaction between youth and rural communities is vital to make sure that AI solutions are responsive to local needs and realities. The discussions have also highlighted the fact that more unity needs to be established among the youth and women in the STEM fields since many young people are working independently without well-coordinated platforms through which they can advocate. In this respect, the examples of attempts to reinforce collective power were referred to the initiatives that strive to bring together female educators and advocates of STEM. It was suggested that youth working groups be created to connect communities to innovation ecosystems, and that AI strategies across Africa formally consider the views of youth at the core.

The need to use differentiated approaches in AI governance is stressed. Women need to be represented in decision-making and leadership positions; children require access to safe, secure consultation mechanisms, supported by accountability processes; and youth need to be formally integrated in the development of strategies, as well as mechanisms of consultation that are safe and secure, with accountability processes being facilitated in support of these mechanisms.

In broader terms, the development and deployment of AI systems should respect, protect, and promote human rights and human dignity, given their increasing role in citizens' social, economic, and political lives. The dialogue highlights the necessity to ensure equity and inclusion, especially the protection of the rights of women, youth, persons with disabilities, marginalized communities, and children, as well as making accessibility easier and having diversity in the design and development of AI. It also emphasizes empowering vulnerable populations by providing them with access to AI resources, training, and innovation programs so that they can fully participate in and benefit from AI developments.

In addition, the dialogue emphasizes that AI should implement transparency, accountability, and human oversight. This involves the need to establish independent oversight bodies, enabling meaningful participation of all stakeholders in AI governance and decision-making processes, and the establishment of inclusive and transparent accountability mechanisms. It also points out that AI systems must be kept within human control with clear responsibility. Ethical use of AI is also necessary, and governance systems need to be operationalized, harmonized, and scaled up to effectively address both the global risks and the national needs without compromising the sight of responsible and ethical AI use.

Thematic Cluster E: Africa's Role in Global AI Governance

To strategically position Africa in global AI governance, participants suggested the development of a set of tangible tools that would enhance open-source ecosystems and sovereign AI infrastructure. This includes the establishment of a Pan-African AI sandbox as a multi-jurisdictional mechanism to enable responsible AI testing and regulatory coordination across the continent. The development of an African AI standard was also recommended as a voluntary compact through which governments embed responsible AI procurement criteria into public sector processes. Such an approach would allow African states to shape markets while aligning innovation with shared governance principles.

Strategic investment in open-source and sovereign AI infrastructure was identified as essential for Africa's position in the global AI landscape. This includes supporting the development of open-source foundation models in African and Arabic languages to ensure technological independence and cultural relevance. A dedicated African AI Innovation Fund was further proposed to mobilize capital and build a strong pipeline of AI ventures. Strengthening Africa's contribution to global AI governance also requires improving the usability of data.

The development of open data catalogues and AI-readiness indices can support countries in assessing the quality and preparedness of publicly available data, addressing the challenge that existing data is often not structured for AI development. The localization of AI systems in African languages was highlighted as both a data sovereignty priority and an educational opportunity. Enabling local contributions to datasets supports the development of context-relevant AI systems while building domestic technical capacity. These measures underscore that Africa's role in global AI governance depends on sustained financial investment, institutional coordination, and active data governance. Strengthening sovereign infrastructure, embedding standards, and improving data readiness are key to ensuring that Africa actively shapes global AI systems rather than remaining a passive participant.

Addis Ababa Declaration on Regional Dialogue on AI Governance

The Addis Ababa Declaration is a continental commitment to AI governance, in which AI is considered not only as a transformative frontier technology for Africa's socioeconomic development, but also calls upon its responsible, inclusive, and development-oriented adoption. It has the following priorities:

I. AI Development and Digital Sovereignty

Promote AI-driven growth, job creation, and innovation in strategic sectors, while encouraging countries to adopt national AI strategies aligned with continental frameworks. This includes supporting local innovation, cultural relevance, and the availability of context-specific solutions, and bridging the digital and AI divide through investments in infrastructure, capacity building, open data, and regional partnerships to strengthen digital sovereignty.

II. Trustworthy and Inclusive AI Governance

Advance secure, trustworthy, and rights-based AI systems grounded in transparency, accountability, human oversight, and the protection of human rights and dignity. This includes inclusive governance through multi-stakeholder participation, independent oversight mechanisms, and strengthened cybersecurity and risk management systems.

III. Global Engagement and Implementation

Affirm Africa's right to actively participate in global AI governance, promoting equitable representation, international cooperation, and access to funding mechanisms. Commitments are to be implemented through national budgets, monitoring frameworks, and continuous dialogue to ensure progress, accountability, and sustained impact.

Recommendations

Recommendations for the UN and International Partners

- Facilitate and support the **development of a common baseline framework** for AI governance across Member States, **build a shared understanding of AI governance**, and ensure coherence across agencies and initiatives.
- Prioritize UN-backed **capacity building and infrastructure support programs**, focusing on STEM and AI skills, digital systems, and foundational connectivity in developing regions. Including teacher training programs, with emphasis on structured educator pipelines and long-term capacity building in developing countries.
- Promote international support for local language AI datasets and education technologies, ensuring linguistic inclusion in digital learning ecosystems.
- Support the establishment of **regional AI regulatory sandboxes**, including cross-border frameworks for testing AI systems in real regulatory environments.
- Scale up **technical assistance for AI-ready data ecosystems**, including support for standardized open data catalogues, data quality frameworks, and shared methodologies for making public data usable for AI applications.
- Strengthen **multi-stakeholder implementation platforms of AI and data governance**, ensuring structured and continuous engagement of governments, the private sector, and civil society in translating global mandates into operational national and regional actions.
- The UN needs to create a **framework to track the implementation of AI governance commitments** (e.g., roadmaps and declarations) with key indicators, regular reviews, and accountability measures to ensure timely and effective implementation and continuity.
- The UN and other partners need to **support African nations in establishing and building capacity in regulatory bodies** to monitor AI systems, set and enforce standards, and address risks such as bias, misuse, and cybersecurity.

Recommendations for Member States

- Invest in **inclusive, context-aware, and culturally grounded AI ecosystems** that reflect Africa's linguistic diversity and social realities, including strong support for local language datasets, improved data representativeness, and applications that respond to community-level needs and priorities.
- Prioritize **AI deployment in high-impact development sectors**, including agriculture, health, education, climate action, and public service delivery, to ensure that AI directly contributes to socio-economic transformation, job creation, and progress toward the Sustainable Development Goals.
- Strengthen coherent national AI governance ecosystems by **aligning AI and data governance frameworks**, while promoting open science, open-source innovation, and responsible AI procurement approaches that enable interoperability, transparency, and the growth of local innovation ecosystems.
- Accelerate **investment in foundational AI enablers and cross-border cooperation mechanisms**, including sovereign and shared digital infrastructure (compute, connectivity, and cybersecurity), blended financing instruments (including SPVs), and regulatory sandboxes to support safe experimentation and regional integration of AI systems.
- Establish and harmonize **AI procurement frameworks that prioritize responsible AI and local innovation ecosystems** across regions (Africa–Middle East cooperation).
- Member States need to **mobilise resources and technical support** to ensure dedicated consultation mechanisms to include youth, children, and marginalised communities in safe spaces and targeted outreach, as well as formal reviews in the development of AI policies.
- Member States need to establish **dedicated mechanisms and technical capacity** to identify algorithmic bias, privacy risks, and AI safety and security risks throughout its entire lifespan.
- Governments need to go beyond data availability to ensure data are standardized, high-quality, and fit for AI, such as by **developing national data quality standards and governance bodies**.
- Member States need to establish processes such as targeted consultations, safe spaces for participation, and review committees to ensure that the **voices of youth, children, and marginalised groups** are incorporated into final AI policies. Invest in sovereign cloud and computing capabilities, locally governed data systems, and data protection legislation; **develop AI strategies with dedicated implementation budgets** that include procurement criteria embedding responsible AI standards; and join a voluntary African AI compact to coordinate procurement of responsible AI across the continent.
- **Reform education systems** from pre-university level to integrate project-based learning and AI literacy, with STEM teacher career pipelines and accountability mechanisms; invest in thin-client smart classroom infrastructure **enabling localized AI models** in resource-constrained contexts; develop AI curricula and datasets in **African languages** to build linguistic sovereignty; and formalize mechanisms for youth working groups to participate in the **development of national AI strategies**.

Conclusion

Inter-regional collaboration between the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia should be strengthened, building on the African Union Continental AI Strategy 2024 and the ESCWA Regional AI Framework. Priority actions will include supporting the development of an African AI-readiness data index and open data catalogue, and scaling data governance programme models across the continent.

Future efforts should prioritize practical instruments over additional principles frameworks. This includes advancing the prototyping of a Pan-African AI sandbox, developing an African voluntary AI standard embedded in procurement systems, investing in sovereign open-source AI foundation models in African languages, and establishing a dedicated African AI innovation fund. The outcomes of this Regional Dialogue should be formally reflected in preparatory documentation for the upcoming global AI dialogue in Geneva. Regional consultations of this nature should continue beyond the Geneva preparatory phase, maintaining momentum toward global engagements in New York in 2027 to ensure sustained progress, accountability, and meaningful African participation in global AI governance.

As a concluding remark, representatives from both UNECA, the African Union Commission (AUC) and Member States reaffirmed strong institutional commitment to the outcomes of the dialogue.

Prof. Saidou Madougou, representing the African Union Commission, expressed appreciation to all panelists for their substantive contributions and emphasized that artificial intelligence is now firmly embedded within the African Union's strategic frameworks, particularly the Science, Technology and Innovation Strategy for Africa (STISA 2034) and the Continental Artificial Intelligence Strategy. He further noted that this dialogue reinforces the positioning of AI not as an emerging issue, but as a core pillar of Africa's long-term transformation agenda.

Mr. Mactar Seck, Chief of the Frontier and Emerging Technologies, Innovation, and Digital Transformation Section at ECA, thanked everyone for their active participation and thoughtful input during the Africa Global Dialogue on AI, especially in identifying Africa's priorities to be presented as its contribution to the Global Dialogue. He highlighted the importance of translating the shared vision and recommendations into tangible actions, emphasising that the real success of this dialogue will be measured by the implementation of inclusive, responsible, and locally relevant AI strategies across Africa. Mr. Seck reaffirmed ECA's commitment to supporting Member States in building robust AI ecosystems, fostering innovation, and ensuring that Africa's digital transformation is equitable and sustainable for all.

Mr. Adolphe Nicaise SAMAFU, Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Post and Digital Economy of the Central African Republic, emphasized the need to convert these dialogues into actionable national and regional initiatives. He highlighted the necessity of effectively implementing AI governance frameworks in order to advance inclusive development and facilitate digital transformation throughout the continent.

Annex I: Consultation Panel

Date: 27 April 2026 | 3:00 – 5:00 p.m. Addis Ababa Time

Session: Special Session E — Regional Dialogue on AI Governance: Regional Priorities and Perspectives on AI Governance

Moderators:

- Chief, Frontier and Emerging Technologies, Innovation, and Digital Transformation Section, ECA, **Mr. Mactar Seck**
- Head of Programme, UN Technology Bank, **Ms. Federica Falomi**

Opening:

- Director of the United Nations Regional Commissions New York Office, **Ms. Thilmeeza Hussain**
- Permanent Representative of El Salvador to the UN and Co-Chair of the Global Dialogue on AI, **H.E. Amb. López (online)**
- Permanent Representative of Estonia to the UN and Co-Chair of the Global Dialogue on AI, **H.E. Amb. Tammsaar (online)**
- Deputy Minister of Technical and Higher Education, Republic of Sierra Leone, **Hon. Sarjoh Aziz Kamara**

Panelists:

1. Chief of ICT Policies, Digital Cooperation and Digital Development, UN - Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia (UN-ESCWA), Beirut, Lebanon, **Ayman El-Sherbiny (online)**
2. Senior Advisor on Artificial Intelligence and Digital Transformation, UN, Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies (ODET), **Dr. Mehdi Snene**
3. Data Policy Advisor, German Agency for International Cooperation (GIZ), Addis Ababa, **Mr. Kuuku Sam Abraham**
4. Founder, Girlhype Coders, South Africa, **Ms. Baratang Albertina Miya**
5. Manager, African Multilateral Affairs, International Relations Central Department, Ministry of Communications and Information Technology, Egypt, **Amr Farouk Safwat (online)**
6. Country Director, STEM Power Ethiopia, **Dr Simenew Keskes**
7. Chief Executive Officer, Betawaves, Tunisia, **Ms. Amel Saidane (online)**
8. CEO, Kontemporary Konsulting, Member of the UN Multi-Stakeholder Advisory Group 2025, **Dr. Jimson Olufuye**
9. Vice-Chancellor (Emeritus), Nnamdi Azikiwe University, Awka Anambra State, Nigeria, **Prof. Charles O. Esimone,**
10. Vice President of the United Nations Association of Uganda (UNA-U), **Ms. Samantha Kkungu**
11. Assistant Research, Fellow at the international Research and Training Centre for Science and Technology Strategy, Strategy (CISTRAT), **Mr. Yan Zhou**
12. Principal Expert – in charge of Innovation, Sustainable Development Finance Department, West African Development Bank (BOAD), **Koffi Fabrice DJOSSOU**

Declaration

- Director Africa Multilateral Cooperation, Department of Science, Technology and Innovation, South Africa, **Ms Mandry Ntshani**

Closing

- Director of department of Education, Science, Technology and Innovation, African Union Commission, **Prof. Saidou Madougou**
- Permanent Secretary at the Ministry of Post and Digital Economy, Republic of Central Africa, **Mr Adolphe Nicaise SAMAFU**
- Chief, Frontier and Emerging Technologies, Innovation, and Digital Transformation Section, ECA, **Mr. Mactar Seck**

ANNEX II: List of Attendees

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Hambani	Mashole ni	unesco	M	mhambani@unesco.org	
2	FEDERICA IKENE	FALOMI	UNTBDC	F	federica.falomi@un.org	
3	Hyunjee	Sung	UNTBDC	F	hyunjee.sung@un.org	
4	JAN	KENNIS	VLRUCS	M	JAN.KENNEL@VLRUCS.BE	
5	Zebadi	Alemagebrie	UNDRR	F	alemagebrie@undrr.org	
6	CHRISTEL-DIANE	Wetche Doube	AM GROUP	F	cdyanbi@gmail.com	
7	Lucas	PAUL O	ANGOLA EMBASSY	M	Paulo.acic@angola.gov.ao	
8	Baratang	Miga	Girltype	F	baratang@girltype.com	
9	Rosalia S andra	Shoko	Elevate Trust	F	rshoko@elevatetrust.org	
10	Vincent Anigbogu	Anigbogu	Institute for National Transformation	M	vanigbogu@gmail.com	
11	Ruth Mekonnen	Gebregeziher	UNECA	F	ruth.gebregeziher@uneca.org	
12	Ayele Legesse	Legesse	Addis Ababa University	M	kiyakantes@ayaleg.com	
13	Shiltone	Qatu	Arigatov Inter.	M	dullahshiltone@gmail.com	
14	Muleta	Ketela	PACE PLC	M	muleta.ketela@paceplc.com	
15	Eyob	Esatu	ISD AFRICA	M	eyob@isd-africa.com	

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Yonas	Gizaw	GreenChem SpA	M	Gizaw.Y@live.com	
2	Peter	Thobane	Ministry of Energy & Petroleum - Kenya	M	gizaw@purdue.edu	
3	Kaihi	HE	Miss. of China	M	hekh@most.cn	
4	Peng	Peng	Miss. of China	M	songp@most.cn	
5	Deborah A	Nantuguna	UNDP	F	ndeborah@undp.org	
6	Rohan	Pathirage	unesco /uis	M	r.pathirage@unesco.org	
7	Xiangping	Tian	CASTED / CISTRAT	F	tiangxp@139.com	
8	Like	Xuan	CASTED / CISTRAT	M	liexuan139@139.com	
9	André KARUE	KARUMBE	MAHE / ATE	M	andrek@karue.com	
10	PAUL	NDIRANGU Kioni	ORIGIN LABS	M	ndirangukioni@originlabs.co.ke	
11	Sadia Janus	Debo	FALA - EAC	F	sadijanus73@gmail.com	
12	Gaiffrey Monari	Monari	HEC and African Entrepreneur	M	gmonari@helb.co.ke	
13	MAVIS	MAUNGANIDZE	ITU	F	mavis.maunganidze@itu.int	
14	Paul-André	CALHAYUD	IRD	M	paul-andre.calhayanud@ird.fr	

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Mariamawit	Ayele	ECA	Female	Mariamawit.ayele@eca.un.org	
2	Laurent	BOCHEREAU	EU DELEGATION AU	M	laurent.bocherEAU@ec.europa.eu	
3	Mandiny	Ntshani	Dept of Science & Tech South Africa	F	mandiny.ntshani@dstec.gov.za	
4	Léonard	LEVEQUE	Ug Sustainable Promotion	M	Leonard-Leveque@cgi-wrth	
5	Sellami	Melchior	CNRST-Algeria	M	m.sellami@cnrst.dz	
6	Landing	Bojani	Dept of Water Resources	M	bojan.l@cgars.com	
7	Angèle B.	SHWENY	TICID	M		
8	Nader	FEIC	UNECA	M	feic@un.org	
9	MARTIAL	ZEBAZE KANA	UNESCO	M	m.zebazE-KANA@unesco.org	
10	Amadou	Gueye	Ministry of Agriculture and Sustainable Development (Senegal)	M	gueyemicae@yahoo.fr	
11	Balla Diop	NGOM	African-TIRS	M	balla.ngom@ucaad.edu.sn	
12	NKEM	KHUMBAH	African Acad of Sci	M		
13	Samuel	CONGOM	African Materials Research Society	M	schienguekhni@un	
14	Besim	Glyco	Hape Fintax	M	besimglyco@gmail	

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Mariamawit	Ayele	ECA	Female	Mariamawit.ayele@eca.un.org	
2	Laurent	BOCHEREAU	EU DELEGATION AU	M	laurent.bocherEAU@ec.europa.eu	
3	Mandiny	Ntshani	Dept of Science & Tech South Africa	F	mandiny.ntshani@dstec.gov.za	
4	Léonard	LEVEQUE	Ug Sustainable Promotion	M	Leonard-Leveque@cgi-wrth	
5	Sellami	Melchior	CNRST-Algeria	M	m.sellami@cnrst.dz	
6	Landing	Bojani	Dept of Water Resources	M	bojan.l@cgars.com	
7	Angèle B.	SHWENY	TICID	M		
8	Nader	FEIC	UNECA	M	feic@un.org	
9	MARTIAL	ZEBAZE KANA	UNESCO	M	m.zebazE-KANA@unesco.org	
10	Amadou	Gueye	Ministry of Agriculture and Sustainable Development (Senegal)	M	gueyemicae@yahoo.fr	
11	Balla Diop	NGOM	African-TIRS	M	balla.ngom@ucaad.edu.sn	
12	NKEM	KHUMBAH	African Acad of Sci	M		
13	Samuel	CONGOM	African Materials Research Society	M	schienguekhni@un	
14	Besim	Glyco	Hape Fintax	M	besimglyco@gmail	

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Mariamawit	Ayele	ECA	Female	Mariamawit.ayele@eca.un.org	
2	LAURENT	BOCHEREAU	EU DELEGATION AU	M	laurent.bochereau@ec.europa.eu	
3	Mandiny	Ntshani	Dept of Science & Tech, South Africa	F	mandiny.ntshani@dstec.gov.za	
4	Léonard	LEVEQUE	LG Sustainable Innovation	M	leonard.levy@lgi-will.com	
5	Sellami	Melchior	CNRST-Algeria	M	m.sellami@cnrst.dz	
6	Landing	Bojan	Dept of Water Resources	M	bojan.bojan@com	
7	Angèle B.	SHWENY	TICID	M		
8	Nadej	FEIC	UNECA	M	feic@uneca.org	
9	MARTIAL	ZEBAZE KANA	UNESCO	M	m.zebaze-kanak@unesco.org	
10	Amadou	Gueye	Ministry of Agriculture and Sustainable Development (Senegal)	M	gueyemica@yahoo.fr	
11	Balla Diop	NGOM	African-TIRS	M	balla.ngom@ucaad.edu.sn	
12	NIKE	KHUMBAH	African Acad of Sci	M		
13	Samuel	CONGOM	African Materials Research Society	M	s.congom@amrs-bw	
14	Besun	Glyco	Haye Fintax	M	besun@hayefintax.com	

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Dawit	Yilma	Addis Ababa University	M	dawit1381@gmail.com	
2	Yohannis	Kidane	Pioneers of Change Africa	M	yohannis.kidane@gmail.com	
3	GININOU	clara	Women Be Free	F	gininou.clara@gmail.com	
4						

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Abiyu	Dagale	Non-governmental	Male	abiyu.dagale@gmail.com	
2	Nouh	Shewangizaw	Academia	Male	nouh.shewangizaw@gmail.com	
3	DAWIT	MAILE	AAU	Male	dawit.esset@gmail.com	
4						

Eighth African Science, Technology and Innovation Forum and the Twelfth Session of the Africa Regional Forum on Sustainable Development Day 2-April 27						
No.	First Name	Last Name	Organization	Gender	Email	Signature
1	Yan	Zhou	CISTRAT	M	131095739@163.com	

ANNEX III: Addis Ababa Declaration

We, the representatives of 22 African Member States, gathered in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia on 27th April 2026 for the Regional Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance, convened by the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia. The regional consultation was attended by 130 participants, taking part both online and in person, Attendees included UN permanent representatives of Estonia and El Salvador (co-chairs of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance), directors and representatives of resident coordinators, international organizations (UN Office of Digital and Emerging Technologies (ODET), UNESCO, ITU, etc.), academia, the private sector, civil society, the technical community, and continental organizations (African Union , Regional Economic Communities, West African Development Bank (BOAD), etc.)

Preamble

Guided by the objectives and principles of the Constitutive Act of the African Union, which promote unity, solidarity, development, and Africa's effective participation in the global economy

Recalling Agenda 2063: The Africa We Want, adopted by the African Union as Africa's long-term strategic framework for inclusive growth, sustainable development, good governance, and global influence;

Acknowledging the Africa Digital Transformation Strategy (2020-2030) as a continental framework guiding Africa's digital future and underscoring the critical importance of aligning AI governance with its principles and priorities to ensure coherence, inclusivity, and sustainability;

Recognising that the African Union's Continental Artificial Intelligence Strategy seeks to advance a development-oriented, Africa-centric, and inclusive approach to artificial intelligence (AI), with an emphasis on building capacity, encouraging innovation, upholding ethics and human rights, and fostering regional collaboration;

Acknowledging the Science, Technology and Innovation Strategy for Africa (STISA 2034), which emphasises science, technology, innovation, and AI as critical enablers of Africa's socio-economic transformation;

Further recalling the adoption of the Global Digital Compact and the establishment of the United Nations Global Dialogue on AI Governance pursuant to United Nations General Assembly Resolution 79/325, and reaffirming Africa's commitment to constructive and meaningful engagement in this global process;

Recognising that AI is a transformative, general-purpose and specific-purpose technology with profound potential to shape Africa's economic development, employment landscape, delivery of public services, social inclusion, peace and security, as well as democratic governance across the continent;

Recognising that AI offers Africa considerable prospects for advancing structural transformation, boosting industrialisation, driving scientific progress, and fostering digital innovation, all in alignment with Agenda 2063 and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development;

Deeply concerned that unequal access to AI-related infrastructure, skills, data, and computing capacity across African countries poses a significant risk of widening existing digital, technological, and socioeconomic divides both within individual nations and between countries across the continent;

Emphasizing the universality, indivisibility, and interdependence of human rights, as well as the obligation of States to respect, protect, and promote human rights, human dignity, democracy, and the rule of law throughout all phases of the development and deployment of AI;

Emphasising also the importance of transparency, accountability, ethical conduct, and meaningful human oversight to ensure that AI serves the public interest and advances people-centred development;

Recognising the importance of regional and international cooperation, multi-stakeholder engagement, and policy coherence in shaping inclusive and interoperable AI governance frameworks;

Recognising further that advancing AI Governance supports Agenda 2063 by accelerating inclusive growth, sustainable development, good governance, human rights, people-driven progress, especially for women, youth, and the marginalised, strengthening Africa's influence globally;

Welcoming the Global Dialogue on AI Governance as a timely and inclusive platform for fostering international cooperation, sharing best practices, and advancing ethical, transparent, and sustainable approaches to artificial intelligence, while ensuring alignment with Africa's priorities under the Africa Digital Transformation Strategy (ADTS) and Agenda 2063.

Acknowledging the four core thematic clusters of the Global Dialogue on AI Governance : *Societal, Cultural, and Economic Dimensions - Bridging AI Divides - Safe and Trustworthy AI- Human Rights and Ethics* as essential pillars for ensuring a cooperative, human-centric approach to technology

DECLARE AS FOLLOWS:

1. AI opportunities and implications on African Development Priorities

Context

AI holds immense potential in unlocking opportunities for economic development in Africa. From an AI governance perspective, the inclusive adoption of AI in Africa could add as much as \$1 trillion to the African GDP by 2035, accounting for almost a third of the region's current GDP, and create 35-40 million digital jobs under full adoption.¹ AI also presents new opportunities and rapid transformations to Africa's key sectors, including finance, education, healthcare, agriculture, energy, climate change, and governance. Nevertheless, the internet connectivity and usage gap is driven by affordability, literacy, and infrastructure barriers, limiting inclusive AI adoption in Africa.

These challenges reinforce AI-related risks such as the exclusion of large segments of the population who lack access to the internet, devices, or digital skills. Related, limited AI adoption capacity also increases the risk that technological change reinforces rather than reduces inequality and benefits wealthier populations while increasing job losses, especially in labour-intensive sectors. In the absence of strategic AI governance, up to 60% of Africa's workforce is vulnerable to automation, particularly

¹ African Development Bank Group. (2025, July 17). Africa's AI revolution: African Development Bank report projects \$1 trillion additional GDP by 2035 if countries use AI to enhance productivity. <https://www.afdb.org/en/news-and-events/press-releases/africas-ai-revolution-african-development-bank-report-projects-1-trillion-additional-gdp-2035-use-ai-enhance-productivity-89619>

in informal and low-skilled jobs.² Africa also faces a governance gap where global AI standards are shaped externally, leaving limited influence for African stakeholders. Bridging the AI governance gap is critical to better tackle Africa's major challenges and risks (including inequality, labour market disruption, weak governance, and digital inclusion) by regulating AI systems, making them inclusive and in line with development goals under strategies such as the African Union AI strategy.

We acknowledge that an agile and appropriate governance and regulatory environment for AI plays a vital role in fostering responsible AI opportunities and establishing an observatory process aligned with African development priorities across societal, economic, and cultural aspects.

Call for Action:

- a) Prioritize the development of AI solutions that support structural change, increase productive employment, foster industrialisation, improve digital public services delivery, and enhance social inclusion throughout the continent.
- b) Leverage AI to boost productivity in key sectors as per national development plans while investing in skills and workforce training to prevent job displacement.
- c) Support African startups, innovators, and researchers to create locally relevant AI solutions that address African challenges and opportunities.
- d) Promote AI models that support African languages and respect cultural values and National history, ensuring accessibility and relevance across diverse communities.
- e) Advocate for the development and adoption of AI governance frameworks that are firmly rooted in Africa's unique development context, address its socioeconomic realities, and ensure its responsiveness to local institutional capacities and cultural diversity.
- f) Encourage all Member States to formulate and adopt national AI strategies that are harmonised with continental frameworks, prioritising ethics, inclusivity, particularly for rural populations, women, and youth, and sustainability.
- g) Develop regulatory sandboxes for AI governance and scalable, cross-border solutions fit for the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA).
- h) Anchor African AI development in a coherent intellectual property framework, including (a) clarification of authorship, inventorship, and ownership of AI-assisted outputs; (b) text-and-data-mining provisions that enable African AI training while protecting rights holders; (c) a continental licensing market for African datasets, models, and language resources; and (d) protection for community-driven and indigenous-language data initiatives.

² African Development Bank Group. (2025). Africa's AI productivity gain [Detailed report]. https://www.afdb.org/sites/default/files/documents/publications/africas_ai_productivity_gain_afdb_detailed_report_1.pdf

- i) Advocate for global AI governance mechanisms that are open, inclusive, multistakeholder, non-prescriptive, and supportive of development, ensuring that African nations can shape diverse pathways in line with their national and regional priorities.

2. Bridging AI and Digital Divides in Africa

Context .

AI deployment across Africa has accelerated significantly over the last decade. Nevertheless, Africa contributes only about 3% of global AI talent, highlighting a major participation gap in the global AI ecosystem.³ Africa has fewer than 40,000 AI-literate professionals, far below what is needed to support large-scale adoption.⁴ The continent faces a 32-point gap in digital skills compared to the G20 average, reflecting a major skills deficit. Only 31% of African universities offer AI programs, and 34% offer data science degrees, limiting talent development pipelines.⁵ These challenges hinder the AI adoption rate in Africa, which remains below 10% in many countries, compared to over 50% in advanced economies.⁶ In addition, the limited data centres in the continent, which are less than 1% of global data-centre capacity, constrains local AI development and deployment. This is also related to building data centres, which demand high energy and water consumption. Africa's data centre capacity (307 megawatts) is less than 2 percent of the global total, and the continent will need at least 1,200 megawatts more by 2030.⁷ Addressing these infrastructure gaps is part of Africa's AI governance.

We recognise the environmental footprint of AI compute, including energy and water consumption of data centres. Member States commit to (i) requiring Environmental and Social Impact Assessments for new data centres above a defined capacity threshold; (ii) prioritising renewable energy sources and water-recycling and outdoor-air cooling practices; and (iii) publishing annual data on AI compute energy and water use, in line with the AU's climate commitments and Agenda 2063.

Call for Action:

- a) Strengthen human capital and enhance institutional capacity in AI across Africa through promoting digital and AI literacy, , and advanced technical skills, including machine learning, data science, cybersecurity, and high-performance computing, especially for youth and women.

³ UNESCO. (2025). AI for Africa by Africa.

https://articles.unesco.org/sites/default/files/medias/fichiers/2025/10/AI_for_Africa_by_Africa_EN.pdf

⁴ Overseas Development Institute. (2025). Brains, bytes, and bottlenecks: Fixing Africa's AI talent gap.

<https://odi.org/en/insights/brains-bytes-and-bottlenecks-fixing-africas-ai-talent-gap/>

⁵ Africa Data Centres Association. (2024, July 17). How Africa can leapfrog the world in sustainable digital infrastructure development. <https://africadca.org/en/how-africa-can-leapfrog-the-world-in-sustainable-digital-infrastructure-development/>

⁶ Business Insider Africa. (2025, October 31). AI is spreading faster than electricity or the internet — but half the world can't join in, Microsoft report says. <https://www.businessinsider.com/ai-fastest-tech-in-history-microsoft-warns-billions-left-out-2025-10>

⁷ Siren Journals (2026) https://sirenjournals.net/uploads/articles/pdfs/article_696b9386727c2.pdf

- b) Support universities, research institutions and technical training centres to develop AI talent pipelines across the continent
- c) Expand access to digital infrastructure, data and high-performance computing resources, with a particular focus on least developed and landlocked countries; this includes investment in digital public infrastructure, data centres and its energy sources, and interoperability standards, while supporting African-led research to enhance digital sovereignty.
- d) Leverage the African Union, United Nations and regional mechanisms to advance and coordinate AI capacity-building efforts;
- e) Promote open-source software, open data and open AI models as public goods to stimulate innovation and entrepreneurship throughout the continent.
- f) Create a necessary Multistakeholder African and National AI sovereignty Task Force.
- g) Affirm Africa's right to access, audit, and adapt foundation models, including through public-interest compute access for African researchers and institutions, .

3. **Safe, Secure and Trustworthy AI Governance**

Trust is foundational to the development, adoption and impact of artificial intelligence, as it ensures that AI systems are not only safe, secure and reliable, but also uphold transparency, accountability and respect for human rights throughout their lifecycle. In Africa, the development of AI systems that are safe, secure, and trustworthy should prioritize robust risk mitigation strategies that address challenges such as misinformation, quality of data, cybersecurity threats, surveillance, and misuse.

We acknowledge the continent needs to transition from general interest to high-level policy implementation centred on the idea that trustworthy AI is not just an ethical requirement, but also a prerequisite for digital sovereignty and economic growth. Trust is foundational to the development, adoption and impact of artificial intelligence, as it ensures that AI systems are not only safe, secure and reliable, but also uphold transparency, accountability and respect for human rights throughout their lifecycle.

Call for Action:

- a) Harmonising African AI governance frameworks with developing global norms and standards, while safeguarding national and regional policy autonomy for sustainable development;

- b) Enhance policy coherence and interoperability among national and regional AI governance approaches within Africa, while preserving policy space for innovation, development, and trust in AI as a force for public good.
- c) Promote by design AI systems that are safe, secure, and trustworthy. As part of this effort, priority should be given to implementing robust risk mitigation strategies that address challenges such as misinformation, quality of data, cybersecurity threats, surveillance, and misuse.
- d) Strengthen cybersecurity readiness, incident response capabilities and resilience .
- e) Foster inclusive and transparent AI accountability mechanisms by establishing national oversight bodies, ensuring meaningful participation of all stakeholders in AI governance decision-making processes across Africa.
- f) Develop context-sensitive data governance frameworks that protect individual privacy, promote ethical data collection and use, and ensure African nations retain sovereignty over data generated on the continent, while enabling responsible cross-border data flows that support regional integration and innovation.
- g) Deploy Algorithmic Impact Assessments and Data Protection Impact Assessments of high-risk AI systems, including biometric, predictive, and automated decision-making systems
- h) Establish accessible redress mechanisms, including AI Ombudsperson functions or equivalent, that allow individuals affected by AI-driven decisions to obtain meaningful explanation, human review, correction, and remedy.

4. Respecting, protecting, and promoting human rights

Context

With AI systems continuing to advance key aspects of society's social, economic, and political life, there is a greater urgency to ensure they are developed and deployed in ways that respect human rights and protect human dignity. Despite initiatives and frameworks launched by various key stakeholders in the past, questions still remain about how these frameworks can be operationalized, harmonized, and scaled to address both global risks and national needs.

The outcome document of the WSIS+20, in its section on “human rights and ethical dimension of the information society”, acknowledges the fundamental importance of human rights in the governance of digital technologies and the implementation of the WSIS Action Lines. Issues addressed by WSIS+20 include digital inclusion and human rights challenges related to AI, online violence, data protection, and algorithmic bias. WSIS+20 reinforced that human rights must serve as a compass for new technologies and digital governance.

We recognise that AI must be governed in full compliance with international law, including international human rights law

Call for Action:

- a) Guarantee equity and inclusion in AI systems to protect the rights of women, youth, persons with disabilities, marginalized communities, and safeguard children. This includes empowering vulnerable groups through access to AI computing resources, targeted training, digital literacy, and innovation programs to unlock opportunities in the AI era.
- b) Advance accessibility and diverse representation in AI design and development to ensure systems reflect Africa's communities.
- c) Ensure AI solutions are accountable to human control.
- d) Prevent algorithmic bias, discrimination, and exclusion by promoting fairness, representative datasets, inclusive design, and regular impact assessments.
- e) Protect privacy and personal data through robust legal, regulatory, and institutional safeguards, including secure and responsible data governance practices.
- f) Prohibit, in law, the deployment of real-time remote biometric identification in publicly accessible spaces, save where strictly necessary, proportionate, and authorised by judicial process for the investigation of serious offences, with mandatory ex-post public reporting.
- g) Affirm that AI development on African territory shall comply with applicable labour rights, including occupational safety and mental-health protections for data-labelling and content-moderation workers, transparency of contracting and platform-mediated employment relationships, and freedom of association. Member States shall coordinate to prevent jurisdictional arbitrage by AI vendors and to require disclosure, in public procurement, of upstream labour conditions in the AI supply chain.
- h) Member States shall adopt safeguards against the use of AI to manipulate elections, generate political disinformation, or impersonate candidates, public officials, or journalists, including through synthetic media. Electoral management bodies shall be supported with technical capacity to detect and respond to AI-enabled electoral interference.
- i) AI systems directed at, or substantially affecting, children shall be subject to heightened safeguards, including age-appropriate design, restrictions on profiling and targeted advertising, parental and guardian rights, and explicit prohibitions on the use of AI in ways that exploit, sexualise, or psychologically harm children.

5. Data integrity, data collection, and data management (cross-cutting consideration)

Context

As of 2026, 76% of African countries have privacy and data-protection legislation, while the AU Malabo Convention on Cyber Security and Personal Data Protection is signed by 21 African nations and ratified by 20 countries.⁸ These progresses are crucial foundations for advancing ethical AI adoption and introduces ethical considerations.

We recognize that governments need to balance citizen protection and sovereignty with efforts to develop data systems that are inclusive, equitable, and reliable.

Call for action:

- a) Require public bodies to create, organize, and maintain data in a manner that ensures integrity and facilitates public accessibility.
- b) Public institutions should make their data accessible by default, following principles of maximum disclosure to promote transparency and public trust, in accordance with the African Commission on Human and Peoples' Rights (ACHPR/Res. 620 (LXXXI) 2024).
- c) Establish clear frameworks for regular data audits and reviews to uphold the accuracy and reliability of information used in public decision-making.
- d) Encourage the development of national and regional standards for data collection and management, focusing on ethical guidelines and best practices to strengthen data quality and public confidence.
- e) Implement continuous training programmes for public officials on data management, security, and privacy to reinforce a culture of stewardship and responsibility.
- f) Establish independent oversight mechanisms to monitor compliance with data collection, integrity, and management standards, providing avenues for public feedback and redress.
- g) maximum disclosure to promote transparency and public trust, in accordance with ACHPR/Res. 620 (LXXXI) 2024. Additionally, establish independent oversight mechanisms

⁸ United Nations Conference on Trade and Development. (2026). *Summary of adoption of e-commerce legislation worldwide*. UNCTAD. <https://unctad.org/topic/ecommerce-and-digital-economy/ecommerce-law-reform/summary-adoption-e-commerce-legislation-worldwide>

to monitor compliance with data collection, integrity, and management standards, providing avenues for public feedback and redress.

- h) Enhance data access for African researchers and regulators, to lower dependence on foreign tech companies to maintain information integrity;
- i) Enforce accountability on technology companies for the spread of misinformation, disinformation, and hate speech, particularly during elections and conflicts.

6. Africa's Position and Role in the Global AI Governance

We emphasise Africa's right to meaningful and effective participation in global AI governance and norm-setting processes.

We call for global governance frameworks that:

- a) Recognise developmental asymmetries and capacity differentials
- b) Prioritise capacity-building, access, and technology cooperation
- c) Encourage interoperable and inclusive governance approaches;
- d) Strengthen African representation in multilateral institutions, technical bodies, and AI governance forums, and enhance the voice of African nations in global decision-making.
- e) Enable financial mechanisms that support the bridging of AI divides within and across African nations.
- f) Operationalise the Intellectual Property (IP) provisions of the AfCFTA IP Protocol and the AU Continental AI Strategy by establishing, through African Regional Intellectual Property Organization (ARIPO), African Intellectual Property Organization (OAPI), and national IP offices, harmonised principle-based IP guidance for AI, including administrative guidance on AI authorship and inventorship, technical infrastructures for rights reservation and licensing, and a continental approach to the protection of African language datasets used as AI training data.
- g) Operationalise dedicated financial mechanisms for AI in Africa, including the Africa AI Fund, blended-finance instruments, sovereign and pension fund participation, and Special Purpose

Vehicles, with priority allocations for AI compute infrastructure, energy and water-efficient data centres, AI talent pipelines, and AI access for least-developed and landlocked countries.

6. Implementation and Way Forward

- a) The Declaration and the outcomes of the Africa Global Dialogue on AI shall be transmitted to the United Nations Global Dialogue on AI Governance as Africa's collective contribution.
- b) An Africa AI Governance Implementation Roadmap shall be developed by the African Union Commission, in consultation with Regional Economic Communities and stakeholders, within six (6) months of adoption, with measurable targets, responsible institutions, and timelines for each commitment in this Declaration.
- c) An annual Africa AI Governance Scorecard shall be published, tracking, at minimum: status of national AI authorities; AI legislation enacted; redress and oversight mechanisms operational; biometric AI deployments and incidents; data-centre capacity and energy/water performance; AI financing disbursed; and African representation in global AI governance bodies.
- d) A successor Africa Global Dialogue on AI shall convene biennially, with a mid-cycle review at Heads of State and Government level, to assess implementation progress and update commitments.
- e) Civil society, academia, regional bodies, the private sector, and affected communities shall participate as full stakeholders in the implementation, monitoring, and review of this Declaration.
- f) Member States commit to publishing, within twelve (12) months of adoption, indicative national AI implementation budgets, including allocations for AI oversight authorities, redress mechanisms, public-interest AI research, and African-language model development.
- g) Call upon the African Development Bank, the Economic Commission for Africa, multilateral development banks, and development partners to align their AI-related financing with this Declaration and to report annually on disbursement and impact.